North India Winter Trip: Overview (6 people)

8 plans compared (7 North India + Nepal) · trains from Hyderabad, Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada · Delhi → Kalka → toy train connections · Airbnb approach · vehicles for 6 · international options checked · winter gear. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

All plans side by side (per person, 6 sharing)

Plan	Where	Snow	Offbeat	Crowds	Transport	Shoestring / recommended
1 · Standard Shimla–Manali	Toy train to Shimla, Kufri, Narkanda–Hatu, Manali, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu, Naggar, Sethan, Kasol	Good	★★☆☆☆	High	Train + toy train + HRTC	**₹23.7k** / ₹32.3k
2 · Offbeat Shimla–Manali	Toy train, Mashobra, Shali Tibba, Narkanda, Thanedar, Jalori, Jibhi, Tirthan, Sethan NYE	Good	★★★★★	Low	Train + toy train + 1 Innova	**₹22.5k** / ₹29.9k
3 · Kashmir	Vande Bharat to Srinagar, Gulmarg, Drung, Doodhpathri, Sonamarg, Pahalgam–Aru, Martand	**Best**	★★★☆☆	Medium	Train all the way	**₹22.3k** / ₹29.6k
4 · Sikkim + Darjeeling	Gangtok, Tsomgo–Nathula, Silk Route (Zuluk, Nathang), Aritar, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong, Darjeeling	At passes only	★★★★☆	Low–medium	Flights to Bagdogra	**₹33.8k** / ₹43.5k
5 · Uttarakhand	Rishikesh, Devprayag, Deoria Tal, Chopta–Tungnath–Chandrashila, Auli–Gorson, Haridwar	Good (trek/Auli)	★★★☆☆	Low–medium	Train + bus + 1 Innova	**₹20.7k** / ₹29.1k
6 · Amritsar + Kangra (new)	Golden Temple, Wagah, Dalhousie–Khajjiar–Dainkund, McLeodganj–Triund, Palampur, Bir, Kangra toy train	Medium	★★★☆☆	Medium	Train + Innova legs	**₹19.1k** / ₹29.0k
7 · Kinnaur winter (new)	Toy train both ways, Narkanda, Sarahan, Sangla, Kalpa, Nako, Shimla NYE	Very good	★★★★★	Very low	Train + toy train + 1 Innova	**₹21.4k** / ₹28.1k
8 · Nepal overland (international)	Kathmandu (3 Durbar Squares, Pashupati, Boudha), Bandipur, Pokhara street festival	No snow (peak views)	★★★☆☆	Medium	Weekly Raxaul train + buses	**₹18.8k** / ₹28.1k

Recommendation

Guaranteed snow → Plan 3 (Kashmir). Offbeat + toy train → Plan 2 or **Plan 7 (Kinnaur)**. **Cheapest → Plan 5. Classic first trip → Plan 1. Something different → Plan 6** (Golden Temple + Himachal). **Abroad → Plan 8 (Nepal)**, the only international trip that fits the budget.

Plan 4 (Sikkim) is beautiful but needs flights, so it goes over ₹30k unless you take the lean version.

Budgets: 6 travellers, 3-bedroom Airbnbs (or 3 homestay rooms), one Innova or taxi-union SUV per circuit. 'Shoestring' = SL trains, ordinary buses, cheaper Airbnbs. 'Recommended' = 3A, Volvo, better-rated stays. The one-time winter clothing purchase (≈ ₹4–6.5k if you own nothing) is not included.

What changed in this version

- **Group of 6:** every cab, Airbnb and Innova cost is split 6 ways. Tatkal tickets need 2 PNRs (max 4 per Tatkal PNR).
- **Airbnb instead of hotels:** each plan lists a best-rated and a budget Airbnb for every stop, with rating, reviews, capacity and an estimated December price for 6. Where Airbnb has nothing (Zuluk, Sari, Sangla, Bandipur…), homestays are named instead.
- **Shimla by toy train from Kalka** (Plans 1, 2, 7). Default: Telangana Exp → Delhi sightseeing day → 21:10 Kalka Mail → 05:20–06:20 toy train (≈ ₹265 pp in trains). Fast option: Tamil Nadu Exp from Kazipet → 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → 12:10 Himalayan Queen (Shimla 25 Dec evening).
- **Boarding at Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada** is now in the train tables with times, plus how to get there with 6 people.
- **Cheapest intermediate trains:** SL on overnight Delhi → Kalka / Jammu / Amritsar / Haridwar runs, 2S on the toy train.
- **New plans:** 6 (Amritsar + Kangra valley), 7 (Kinnaur by toy train), 8 (Nepal overland). International and other options that don't fit are explained at the end.

Calendar & booking deadlines

Date	Day	What it means
24 Dec 2026	Thursday	Start. 12285 Duronto (Sun/Thu) and 17005 Hyderabad–Raxaul (Thu only) both run today.
25 Dec	Friday	Christmas. Most trains from Telangana reach Delhi this morning. Red Fort is open (closed Mondays).
26 Dec	Saturday	Weekend crowds in Shimla/Manali/Mussoorie. Nathula usually open (closed Mon/Tue).
31 Dec	Thursday	New Year's Eve. Airbnb rates peak; 2–3 night minimum stays are common for 30 Dec–1 Jan.
1 Jan 2027	Friday	Heavy traffic down from the hills. 12286 Duronto NZM→SC runs (Mon/Fri).
2 Jan	Saturday	Leave Delhi: 12724 Telangana Exp 16:00 or 22692 Rajdhani (late evening) → home 3 Jan.
3 Jan	Sunday	Must be home. Keep it as buffer only.

Journey date	General booking opened (60-day rule)	Tatkal (day before)
24 Dec 2026 (onward)	25 Oct 2026 (open now)	23 Dec: 10:00 AC / 11:00 SL
25 Dec (Delhi → Kalka / Jammu / Amritsar)	26 Oct 2026 (open now)	24 Dec 10:00 / 11:00
1 Jan 2027	2 Nov 2026 (open now)	31 Dec 10:00 / 11:00
2 Jan 2027 (return)	3 Nov 2026 (open since yesterday)	1 Jan 10:00 / 11:00

6 people = 1 PNR in general quota (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

Do these today (4 Nov)

1. **Return train for 2 Jan** (window opened 3 Nov). For Nepal: **17005 for 24 Dec** (weekly) + 12792 for 2 Jan.
2. **Onward train for 24 Dec** using the station-by-station check below, then the 25 Dec connection (Kalka Mail / Jammu Mail / Amritsar train) and the toy train for 26 Dec.
3. **NYE-night Airbnbs (30 Dec–1 Jan)** with flexible cancellation. Hosts set minimum stays and these sell out first.

Hyderabad → Delhi on 24 Dec: every boarding option

Train	Where you board (time)	Reaches Delhi	Runs	Fare / person (SL · 3A)	Use it for
12723 Telangana SF Exp	**Hyderabad Deccan 06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25 · Kazipet 08:03/08:05	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Default.** Cheapest, boards in the city. Delhi day + night train/bus onward
12621 Tamil Nadu SF Exp	Vijayawada 03:50–04:05 · Warangal 06:50/06:52 · **Kazipet 06:55**	New Delhi **06:30** (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950 (from Kazipet)	**Fast option.** Catches the 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → Shimla same evening
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 07:00/07:10 · Kazipet ~08:50	H. Nizamuddin 05:30	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 (meals incl.)	Fast and comfortable but ~2× the 3A fare
12625 Kerala SF Exp	Vijayawada ~10:10–10:55 · Warangal ~13:30 · **Kazipet 13:45**	New Delhi 13:30	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Backup if 12723 is full (leave Hyderabad by 09:30 by bus)
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad 12:50	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40	Sun & Thu	3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Runs on 24 Dec (Thu)
12615 Grand Trunk Exp	Vijayawada ~01:00–02:00 · Kazipet 04:00 (very early 24 Dec)	New Delhi 05:10	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Only if you can leave Hyderabad around midnight
12721 Dakshin SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan 23:00 · Kazipet ~01:15	H. Nizamuddin ~03:45 on 26 Dec	Daily	≈ ₹780 · ≈ ₹2,100	Evening departure; costs you a day
17005 Hyderabad–Raxaul Exp	Hyderabad Deccan **23:10** · Secunderabad 23:30	— (Raxaul, Nepal border ~17:00 Sat 26 Dec)	**Thu only**	≈ ₹870 · ≈ ₹2,300	**Nepal plan**
Weekly via Kacheguda: 12647 Kongu, 12649/12629 K. Sampark Kranti, 12781 Swarna Jayanti	Kacheguda (times vary)	H. Nizamuddin	1–2× a week	SL / 3A	Check if one runs on 24 Dec

Getting to Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada with 6 people: Kazipet and Warangal are ~140 km (2.5–3 h). TGSRTC buses run through the night from JBS/Uppal to Hanamkonda (≈ ₹200–300), or an Innova one-way ≈ ₹4,000–5,000 (≈ ₹750 pp). Vijayawada is ~275 km (5–6 h). Only worth it if Hyderabad quota is full, because you'd need an overnight bus on 23 Dec.

12723 halts in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (~18 halts, ~1,680 km). Confirmed: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30.

How to check every station and halt and actually get 6 seats

- **1. Direct pairs.** On IRCTC / ConfirmTkt / ixigo, search 24 Dec: HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, **KZJ→NDLS, WL→NDLS, BZA→NDLS** (Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada have their own quotas). Note AVAILABLE / RAC / WL for every train above.
- **2. Every halt.** If HYB→Delhi is WL, search the same train from HYB to each later halt (Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur). A shorter ticket can be AVAILABLE when the full one is WL. Ride to Agra, then any Agra→Delhi train or bus (2–3.5 h).
- **3. Book from the origin.** For trains starting elsewhere (22691 from Bengaluru, 12621 from Chennai, 12625 from Thiruvananthapuram), search origin→Delhi and set **Boarding Point** = Secunderabad / Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada. You pay the full-route fare but get the origin's quota.
- **4. Split it.** HYB→Nagpur + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains a day). Keep 2–3 h between them.

- **5. Tatkal on 23 Dec** (AC 10:00, SL 11:00), 2 PNRs of 3 people each. Premium Tatkal costs more but confirms more often.
- **6. Tick Vikalp + auto-upgrade** and only hold WL if it is under ~WL 20 (3A) / WL 40 (SL) this far out.
- **6 people = 1 PNR in general quota** (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

> **Why there are no live 'available / WL' numbers here**
>
> IRCTC, ConfirmTkt, erail and Airbnb pages can't be opened from this environment (blocked), so train numbers, days, times and fares come from search results across several timetable sites. The availability check takes ~10 minutes in the ConfirmTkt or ixigo app, which also shows confirmation chances and alternate stations.

Delhi → Kalka → Shimla toy train

If you arrive in Delhi on…	Delhi → Kalka	Kalka → Shimla (toy train)	In Shimla	Buffers	Train cost / person
12723 Telangana · New Delhi ~07:40 (25 Dec)	**12311 Netaji (Kalka Mail)**, Old Delhi ~21:10 → Kalka ~03:00–04:40 (SL)	**52453 Kalka–Shimla Exp** ~06:00–06:20 (2S ≈ ₹65) or 52451 Shivalik Deluxe ~05:20–05:45 (CC ≈ ₹510)	~10:30–11:50 on 26 Dec	~13 h in Delhi = a sightseeing day; 1–3 h in Kalka waiting room	**≈ ₹265** (SL ≈ ₹200 + 2S ₹65)
12621 Tamil Nadu · New Delhi 06:30	**12011 Kalka Shatabdi**, New Delhi 07:40 → Kalka 11:40–11:45 (CC ≈ ₹885 incl. meal)	**52455 Himalayan Queen** 11:55–12:10 → ~17:20 (CC ≈ ₹265; 2S cheaper)	~17:20 on **25 Dec**	70 min at New Delhi (fog risk), ~25 min at Kalka (timed connection)	≈ ₹1,150
22691 Rajdhani · Nizamuddin 05:30	Same 12011 Shatabdi (Nizamuddin → New Delhi 15–20 min by metro/cab)	52455 Himalayan Queen	~17:20 on 25 Dec	~2 h at Delhi	≈ ₹1,150
12625 Kerala · New Delhi 13:30	12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10 (or 12005 Kalka Shatabdi 17:15 → 21:15 + a night in Kalka)	52453 / 52451 next morning	~11:00 on 26 Dec	~7.5 h Delhi	≈ ₹265

Late-December fog regularly delays trains from the south by 1–4 h. If the fast option misses the 07:40 Shatabdi, fall back to the Kalka Mail at night: you lose half a day, not the trip. Book the Shatabdi only after checking the Tamil Nadu Express running status the evening before (Tatkal opens 10:00 on 24 Dec).

Direction	Train	Departs	Arrives	Classes & approx fare	Notes
Kalka → Shimla	52457 Kalka–Shimla (earliest)	~03:30	~08:55	2S / FC	Listed by some 2026 guides. Verify; may be seasonal
Kalka → Shimla	72451 Rail Motor Car	05:10–05:25	~09:30	≈ ₹320	Glass-roof railcar, 14–18 seats; runs only with enough bookings
Kalka → Shimla	52451 Shivalik Deluxe	05:20–05:45	~10:05–10:40	CC ≈ ₹510 (breakfast incl.)	Fastest regular train
Kalka → Shimla	**52453 Kalka-Shimla Exp**	06:00–06:20	~11:05–11:50	**2S ≈ ₹65**; FC higher	Cheapest reserved seat
Kalka → Shimla	52455 Himalayan Queen	11:55–12:10	~17:20	2S cheap · CC ≈ ₹265 · FC ≈ ₹475	Connects with the 12011 Shatabdi
Shimla → Kalka	52456 Himalayan Queen	10:40	16:10	As above	Connects to evening Delhi trains
Shimla → Kalka	52458 Passenger	14:20–14:25	~20:10	2S / FC	

Direction	Train	Departs	Arrives	Classes & approx fare	Notes
Shimla → Kalka	52452 Shivalik Deluxe	17:40–17:50	~22:25–22:45	CC ≈ ₹510	Connects to the overnight Kalka Mail to Delhi
Shimla → Kalka	52454 Kalka–Shimla Exp	18:25–18:30	~23:20–23:30	2S ≈ ₹65	

Timings differ by 10–25 min between sources (travelcoffee 2026, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, totaltraininfo). Confirm on IRCTC/NTES when you book. Book toy-train seats on IRCTC as soon as the main train is confirmed; 25–26 Dec sells out. Sit on the right side going up for the valley views. The Him Darshan Vistadome (≈ ₹630) runs on some dates.

The Delhi gap on 25 Dec

Delhi day on 25 Dec (Friday, Christmas): luggage + Old Delhi circuit. From New Delhi station take the Yellow Line 2 stops to Chandni Chowk. Leave bags at the Delhi Jn (Old Delhi) cloak room (≈ ₹30–60 per bag per day; bags must be locked).

Red Fort (₹35 Indians, opens 09:30, closed Mondays) → **Jama Masjid** → **Chandni Chowk** food (Paranthe Wali Gali, Old Famous Jalebi Wala) → **Gurudwara Sis Ganj**. Then the Metro to Central Secretariat for **Kartavya Path / India Gate**, **Agrasen ki Baoli**, **Connaught Place**. Christmas evening service at **Sacred Heart Cathedral**. Back at Old Delhi by 20:30.

Cost ≈ ₹600–900 pp (metro day pass ₹200, entries, food). Christmas crowds are heavy at CP and India Gate after 17:00.

Back to Hyderabad by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Fare (SL · 3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈ 20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr next day	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100	Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹780 · ≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00
12792 Danapur–Secunderabad SF Exp	Danapur (Patna) **12:15**	Secunderabad ~21:30 next day	Daily	≈ ₹840 · ≈ ₹2,200	**Nepal plan**: leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan night
17006 Raxaul–Hyderabad	Raxaul 03:15	Hyderabad Deccan 19:40 next day	Sun only	≈ ₹870 · ≈ ₹2,300	No: 3 Jan departure reaches 4 Jan

Flights (only where they help)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (peak ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7
Hyderabad → Chandigarh	IndiGo (≈2 daily)	~2 h 30 m	₹7,000–9,500	Plans 1, 2, 7 (Kalka is 25 km from IXC)
Hyderabad ↔ Srinagar	IndiGo, Air India Express	~3 h	₹9,600–11,100 (peak to ~₹15,700)	Plan 3
Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra	IndiGo (+ Air India Express)	~2 h 20 m	₹6,500–8,500 (peak ₹9–12k)	Plan 4
Hyderabad ↔ Dehradun	IndiGo (~10 flights/week)	~2 h 25 m	₹5,000–9,000	Plan 5

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares, ixigo (Nov 2026), not live quotes. IndiGo: 7 kg cabin + 15 kg check-in on most fares. Fares climb weekly from here for 24 Dec and 2 Jan.

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025–26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Airbnb: how to get best-rated and cheapest for 6

- **Filters:** Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.
- **Best-rated vs cheapest:** sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.
- **Winter questions to message the host before booking:** room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.
- **NYE rules:** many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.
- **Where Airbnb is thin** (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

International trips checked

Destination	How	Main cost driver	Realistic per person (6 people, 24 Dec–3 Jan)	Verdict
Nepal (Kathmandu, Bandipur, Pokhara)	17005 Hyderabad→Raxaul (Thu 23:10) · walk into Birgunj · back via Patna + 12792	Trains ~₹1,700 SL total; no visa (passport or voter ID)	**≈ ₹19–28k** (shoestring–recommended)	**Fits. Full plan included (Plan 8)**
Bhutan (Thimphu, Punakha, Paro)	Fly HYD→Bagdogra + 160 km to Phuentsholing	SDF ₹1,200/person/night + flights ₹13–17k + Bhutan car	≈ ₹40–46k	Over budget
Sri Lanka	IndiGo / SriLankan direct HYD–CMB	Return flights ₹21–35k in Dec	≈ ₹38–50k	Over budget
Thailand	IndiGo / Thai / Nok direct HYD–BKK	Return flights from ~₹27k (mid-Dec); higher at Christmas. Visa-free rules changing in 2026	≈ ₹45–55k	Over budget
Malaysia	AirAsia / Malaysia Airlines direct HYD–KUL	One-way ₹14–18k at Christmas; visa-free only till 31 Dec 2026	≈ ₹45–55k	Over budget
Vietnam	Connecting flights + e-visa (~US$25)	Flights ₹18–22k+	≈ ₹45–55k	Over budget

Visa notes (Nov 2026 reports): Nepal and Bhutan need no visa for Indians (passport or voter ID). Sri Lanka has a free ETA for Indians. Malaysia is visa-free till 31 Dec 2026, so travel after that needs checking. Thailand's visa-free stay for Indians is being cut to 30 days. Vietnam needs an e-visa.

Other North India options considered

Also considered (North India)	Why it is not a full plan
Spiti in winter (Kaza, Langza, Hikkim, Key, Chicham)	Reachable only via Kinnaur in winter. Needs ~8 days from Shimla plus 2 train days each way, so it doesn't fit 24 Dec–3 Jan without a flight back. Most homestays close; −20 °C nights. Operator packages ₹24–36k + travel. Plan 7 covers Kinnaur (the lower half of the same road).
Ladakh in winter	Fly-in only (Delhi–Leh ₹5–9k each way + HYD–DEL); −15 to −25 °C; 2 acclimatisation days. ≈ ₹38–45k.
Mussoorie–Landour–Dhanaulti	Easy and cheap but little snow in late Dec. Listed as a variant inside Plan 5.
Kumaon (Nainital, Mukteshwar, Munsiyari)	Good alternative to Plan 5. Munsiyari is 10–11 h beyond Kathgodam. Listed as a variant in Plan 5.

Winter gear: buy vs rent

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent
Trekking pole	Treks	₹400–700	₹50–100/day	Rent
Ski kit	Optional	—	Gulmarg ≈ ₹700/day + jacket ₹300 + trouser ₹200; Solang/Auli lesson ₹1,000–2,500	Optional
Cold cream, SPF 50, lip balm, hand-warmers	Must	₹500–700 total	—	Buy

Where to buy before you leave Hyderabad

- **Decathlon** (several Hyderabad stores, plus online): thermals, fleece, padded jackets, MH100/MH500 shoes, gloves, socks.
- Koti / Begum Bazaar / Sunday markets: cheaper woollens, caps, socks (₹100–300).
- Delhi on 25 Dec: Monastery Market (Majnu ka Tilla), Janpath and Sarojini Nagar for cheap jackets.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

- IRCTC 60-day ARP & 2026 Aadhaar-verified booking: Business Today, India TV, Upstox, Trainman blog, india.com, Patrika
- Kazipet/Warangal/Vijayawada timings (12621, 12625, 12615, 12721, 22691): ConfirmTkt, ixigo, Goibibo, Paytm, MakeMyTrip, indiarailinfo, RailMitra
- Kalka Mail / Kalka Shatabdi / toy train: Cleartrip, RailMitra, indiantrain, totaltraininfo, ixigo, Bajaj Finserv, travelcoffee 2026, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia
- 17005/17006 & 12791/12792: ixigo, totaltraininfo, ConfirmTkt, RailMitra, Trainman; Jammu Mail 14033: ConfirmTkt, indiantrain
- Vande Bharat Jammu–Srinagar: Kashmir Life, NewsX, Inshorts (2026); Kangra toy train restoration: Outlook Traveller, Curly Tales (June 2026)
- Vehicle rates: Rajputana Cabs, Triveni Cabs (2026); Airbnb listings via airbnb.com/.co.in search results (Nov 2026)
- International: Consulate General of India Phuentsholing (Bhutan SDF), HappyFares/Business Today (Nepal), Skyscanner/IndiGo/AirAsia/Trripah fares, Esquire India, Skyscanner cheapest-countries guide
- Spiti winter: discoverwithdheeraj, treksandtrails, Spiti Holiday Adventure; Kinnaur winter: vargiskhan, travelcoffee